Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 3 — Academic vs Encyclopedic Writing: what is your message?

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2. What is your message?
3. How can you convince people?

Roadmap

1. Why should we write?
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2. What is your message?
3. How can you convince people?

Purpose of Writing in the Humanities and Social Sciences

- Writing is both a **tool for thinking** and a **means of communication**.
- It helps clarify ideas, interpret texts, and contribute to scholarly conversations.
- Written work demonstrates:
  - Understanding of key issues
  - Ability to argue persuasively
  - Awareness of disciplinary methods
- Writing is a process of *inquiry and reflection*, not merely reporting.
- Aim: to explore questions, not just provide answers.

Partly based on Analyzing Texts, Taking Notes (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 1)

Humanities, Social Sciences, and Linguistics

- All three analyze human experience, culture, society, *and* language.
- **Humanities:**
  - Interpret texts, artworks, languages, and histories.
  - Value close reading, interpretation, argumentation.
- **Social Sciences:**
  - Study human behavior, institutions, and systems.
  - Employ observation, evidence, and models.
- **Linguistics:** (bridging H/SS; both theoretical and empirical)
  - *General:* structure and use of language
  - *Variation & change:* sociolinguistics, dialectology, historical linguistics.
  - *Mind & processing:* psycholinguistics, neurolinguistics.
  - *Data & methods:* corpora, fieldwork/elicitation, experiments, formal modeling.
  - *Technology & applications:* computational linguistics/NLP, lexicography, language documentation.

All rely on

- Critical analysis and evidence-based reasoning
- Clear written communication tailored to audience and genre

Writing as Inquiry

- Writing helps generate ideas and refine questions.
- Early drafts explore possibilities rather than finalize conclusions.
- Revision is discovery: each draft deepens understanding.
- Effective writers balance:
  - **Open exploration** with
  - **Focused argumentation**.
- Thinking happens through writing, not before it.

Academic Conversations

- Academic writing joins an ongoing **conversation of ideas**.
- You engage with others by:
  - Quoting and analyzing sources
  - Summarizing and synthesizing prior work
  - Acknowledging different viewpoints
- Essays must both *respond to* and *extend* these discussions.
- Citations show respect for others' intellectual labor.
- Every essay adds a new voice to the dialogue.

Voice and Style

- Academic writing has a clear, confident voice.
- Strive for:
  - Precision over ornamentation
  - Clarity over complexity
  - Variety in sentence structure
- Avoid jargon unless necessary.
- Use active verbs and concise phrasing.
- Revision improves tone and flow.
- Essays need logical progression of ideas.
  - Use outlines to maintain focus.
  - Ensure every section supports the thesis.

Revising and Editing

- Revision refines both ideas and expression.
- Strategies:
  - Read aloud to test clarity
  - Seek peer or instructor feedback
  - Review argument flow
  - Cut redundancy
- Editing focuses on grammar, punctuation, and formatting.
- Always proofread before submission.

Academic Integrity

- Uphold honesty in research and writing.
- Avoid plagiarism by citing all borrowed ideas.
- Keep detailed notes on sources.
- Paraphrase thoughtfully; don't just reword sentences.
- Academic trust depends on intellectual transparency.

Reading for Writing

- Treat writing as a **thinking process** that begins with reading and note-taking.
- Approach every lecture, discussion, and reading as a **text** to analyze.
- Ask questions continually; **do not read passively**.
- Build habits that connect reading notes to future **essay arguments**.
- Aim to understand *how* a “verbal contraption” works, not just what it says.

Partly based on Analyzing Texts, Taking Notes (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 1)

What Counts as a “Text”?

- Any statement encountered in class: readings, **lectures**, prepared discussions.
- Analyze texts **all the time**, not only when told to.
- Compare new material with prior readings, lectures, and beliefs.
- Write thoughts down—notes become the **foundation** of essays.
- Focus on both **content** and **method**: what it says and how it works.

Active Reading Mindset

- Break the text into parts to see **purpose** and **mechanism**.
- Notice use of plot, imagery, symbolism, allusion (not just in literature).
- Recognize that nonfiction also deploys **language tools** strategically.
- Read to discover **patterns**, not only to collect facts.
- Remember: analyzing others' writing prepares you to **write interpretively**.

General Questions to Drive Analysis

- What confuses you? What needs **clarification**?
- Which claims are most **central** to the text's project?
- How do structure and language **support** those claims?
- What assumptions or **premises** are in play?
- How does this text relate to other course materials and **your concerns**?

For Fiction (Mostly)

- **Narrator**: who tells the story? reliable/unreliable/biased?
- **Setting & tone**: what senses and emotions are evoked?
- **Characters**: motivations, alignments, identification cues.
- **Language/diction**: level and implications.
- **Plot/structure**: problems, challenges, archetypes.
- **Images/motifs**: repetitions, metaphors, patterns.
- **Ending**: what resolves? why end *there*?

For Nonfiction (Mostly)

- **Author**: background and qualifications.
- **Audience**: allies, opponents, or neutral readers?
- **Intention**: explanatory, polemical, celebratory—*why* written?
- **Structure**: how is the argument organized?
- **Appeals**: logic vs. emotion; what types of arguments are used?

On Arguments: Classical Roots

- Aristotle analyzed features of argument still relevant today.
- Logic is central to many, but not all, arguments.
- A **syllogism** shows how accepted premises force a conclusion.
- Recognize that not all premises are **incontrovertible**.
- Much real-world reasoning yields **probable** rather than absolute conclusions.

Deduction (Syllogism) in Brief

- Moves from accepted premises to a **necessary** conclusion.
- If premises hold, disputing the conclusion is **illogical**.
- Useful when shared facts/definitions exist.
- Limits: debates often target the **premises** themselves.
- Practice: state premises explicitly; test their **soundness**.

Induction

- Starts from observations/data and infers a **generalization**.
- Conclusions are **tentative** (we never observe everything).
- Science frames even strong theories as **revisable**.
- Good induction “**follows the data**.”
- Beware overreach; match claim strength to **evidence**.

Narrative as Argument

- Stories and anecdotes can **persuade** by identification.
- History blends data, concepts, and **narrative structure**.
- Narrative can sometimes substitute for data or axioms.
- The most powerful stories **engage emotion**.
- Ask why a writer turns to story—what **work** is narrative doing?

Reason, Emotion, and Premises

- Distinguish appeals to **reason** vs. **emotion**.
- Identify the trail from premises to conclusion.
- Test premises for **assumptions**, generality, and evidence.
- Map where uncertainty lies: data, inference, or **values**.
- Use your notes to plan a balanced, **well-supported** response.

Quick Note-Taking Checklist

- Capture **central question** and main claims.
- Mark **evidence** and how it supports claims.
- Flag **key terms**, metaphors, and recurring motifs.
- Record **questions** and possible counterarguments.
- Synthesize into a **one–two sentence** takeaway for future drafting.

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What Is a Thesis?

- A thesis is a claim that can be **defended with reasons and evidence**.
- It is neither a topic nor a fact, but an **interpretation**.
- Example:
  - Topic: “Women in Shakespeare.”
  - Thesis: “Shakespeare’s comedies use disguise to challenge gender norms.”
- A thesis makes a promise to the reader about the essay’s direction.

From Question to Argument

- Start with a genuine **question or problem**.
- Narrow broad curiosity into a focused inquiry.
- Ask “*How? Why? So what?*” about your topic.
- As you read and write, your tentative answer becomes a **working thesis**.
- Revise the thesis as new evidence appears.

Characteristics of a Strong Thesis

- **Debatable**: reasonable people could disagree
- **Specific**: not a vague generality
- **Focused**: answerable in the space you have
- **Insightful**: says something not already obvious
- **Connected**: matches the evidence you actually have

Weak — announces a topic	**Strong** — takes a stance
"This essay will discuss social media and teenagers."	"Social media intensifies teenage anxiety by rewarding performative identity."
"This essay will discuss data centres and water."	"Data centre water use is small nationally but heavy locally, so it should be reported by watershed."

A strong thesis makes the reader ask **how?** and **why?**

Refining Your Thesis

- Expect early theses to be **rough hypotheses**.
- Strengthen by:
  - Clarifying key terms.
  - Tightening scope.
  - Checking consistency with evidence.
- Ask peers to summarize your claim—does it match your intent?
  - **That is what we are about to do with your water paragraphs.**
- Revision turns a statement into a compelling argument.

Common Pitfalls

- Thesis too **broad** or too **narrow**.
- Merely **summarizes** instead of analyzing.
- Contains **multiple, unconnected** claims.
- Uses vague verbs: “shows,” “is about,” “explores.”
- Fails to anticipate **counterarguments**.

Purpose and Tone Across Disciplines

Humanities	Persuasive, interpretive, argument-driven. Focus on ideas and textual evidence.
Social Sciences	Empirical, objective tone. Focus on testing hypotheses, describing data.
Linguistics	Analytical, combining theory and data. Balances conceptual framing with empirical evidence.
Computer Science	Technical, concise, performance-oriented. Emphasis on algorithms, models, evaluation metrics.

How Arguments Are Built

- **Humanities:** logic of persuasion → evidence supports an interpretation.
- **Social Sciences:** logic of proof → evidence tests a hypothesis.
- **Linguistics:** logic of demonstration → evidence shows a pattern or contrast.
- **Computer Science:** logic of replication → results must be reproducible.
- **All:** aim for clarity, coherence, and a sense of contribution.

Encyclopedic Writing: Wikipedia Style

- **Purpose:** inform, not argue — summarize accepted knowledge.
- **Tone:** neutral, verifiable, non-original.
- **Structure:** topic-based, not narrative.
  Overview → *Subtopics* → *References*.
  Lead → *Body* → *Appendices* Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Layout
- **Comparison:**
  - Unlike research writing, no new data or interpretation.
  - Like the introduction of an academic paper, it provides context and key sources.
  - Ideal for background reading, not for advancing claims.

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From Topic to Argument

- Move from gathering ideas to **building a case**.
- Prefer **logical** appeals; use emotion sparingly and purposefully.
- Choose modes of reasoning suited to your materials.
- Keep conclusions **tentative yet confident**—acknowledge limits.
- Let structure make your thinking **followable** for readers.

Partly based on Ordering Evidence, Building an Argument (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 4)

Worry about the structure more than the style

Prose is architecture, not interior decoration, and the Baroque is over.
Ernest Hemingway (1932) *Death in the afternoon*

- Build on a **solid foundation**: thesis and linked reasons.
- **Form follows function**: structure should serve clarity.
- Mechanical scaffolding may be invisible, but must exist.
- Avoid random piles of points; design for **coherence**.

Outline: Before or After Drafting

- Two approaches
  - A sketch a **pre-outline** of controlling ideas (topic sentences).
  - B **draft first**, then reverse-outline to reveal logic.
- Either way, ensure the essay is **going somewhere**, not circling.
- Expect to **add/subtract/rearrange**—everything is tentative mid-process.
- Use outlines to test **progression** and **balance**.

- I [FCB] normally write an outline and collect notes as I go along, then write prose at the end. I write a rough introduction first, but revise it at the end, as I almost always change many details, …

The Working Model (Intro–Body–Conclusion)

- **Introduction**: hook interest; give only necessary context; state thesis.
- **Body**: organize supporting ideas into coherent paragraphs.
  - **Transitions**: create **meaningful** links, avoid monotony.
  - **Support**: back each assertion with **textual or data** evidence.
- **Conclusion**: reconnect claims; answer "*so what?*"; mirror the intro.

Paragraphs as Structural Beams

- Each paragraph advances **one** controlling idea.
- Start with a **topic sentence** tied to the thesis.
- Develop with **evidence + analysis**, not lists of facts.
- End by **linking forward** to the next step in the argument.
- Trim digressions; keep the **load-bearing** path visible.

Audience and Explicitness

- Define key terms; avoid assuming shared premises.
- Make **premises** and **purposes** explicit.
- Explain why evidence is **relevant**, not just that it exists.
- Balance brevity with the reader's need for **orientation**.
- Prefer **readability** over flourish: clarity persuades.

What you should aim for

- **Logical sequence**; momentum without stalls.
- **Smooth transitions**; visible through-line from thesis to conclusion.
- Claims **properly supported**; no orphan generalizations.
  - Reliable sources clearly and correctly cited
- Overall emphasis aligns with the essay's **central question**.

Acknowledgements I

- The first sections were based on A Short Handbook for Writing Essays in the Humanities and Social Sciences (Allosso & Allosso, 2019)
- I also consulted Reid (2024) and Krause (2007)

Acknowledgements II

- **GPT-4o** in ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2025) was used to format the references, and generate a first draft of the slides with a prompt like

  ```
  Please make me some slides, based on Chapter 1:
  https://mlpp.pressbooks.pub/writinghandbook/chapter/chapter-1/
  Make them in LaTeX, using luatex and biber, please make around 15
  slides with at least 5 bullet points, use sub-lists where appropriate.
  ```

- I then heavily rewrote them.
- **Claude Opus 5** (Anthropic, 2026) was used to check the slides: to resolve every DOI against Crossref, fetch every URL, and compare each quotation with its original. The prompt was of the form

  ```
  Verify every claim, DOI, URL and quotation against a real source. Where you cannot
  verify something, say so rather than guessing --- never invent a reference.
  ```

  Each correction names the source it was checked against. Responsibility for what remains is mine.

References I

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Appendix

These frames are here for reference: they repeat material from another session, or go further than we had time for.

Developing a Question or Problem

- Essays begin with a focused, arguable question.
- Good questions are:
  - Specific but open-ended
  - Grounded in evidence
  - Worth investigating
- Avoid merely factual or yes/no questions.
- Examples:
  - Weak: “Was Shakespeare popular?”
  - Strong: “How did Shakespeare’s use of rhetoric shape his political commentary?”

Thesis and Argument

- The **thesis** presents your central claim.
- An argument:
  - States a position clearly
  - Provides reasons and evidence
  - Anticipates counterarguments
- Strong theses are *debatable*, not descriptive.
- Structure builds logically from premise to conclusion.
- Each paragraph contributes to proving the thesis.

Evidence and Interpretation

- Evidence supports reasoning; interpretation connects evidence to claims.
- Types of evidence:
  - Textual quotation and analysis (Humanities)
  - Data, case studies, and surveys (Social Sciences)
- Avoid summary; explain significance.
- Analyze patterns and implications.
- Show how evidence leads logically to your conclusions.

Audience Awareness

- Write for an informed but critical audience.
- Assume readers understand the basics but not your interpretation.
- Provide context and define specialized terms.
- Anticipate objections and address them respectfully.
- Maintain an academic tone—formal but engaging.

Becoming a Scholar

- Writing transforms students into active participants in knowledge creation.
- Scholars:
  - Read critically
  - Write reflectively
  - Engage ethically with others' ideas
- Cultivate curiosity and persistence.
- Scholarship is a shared, evolving conversation.

Writing Across Disciplines

- **Humanities:** build an argument through interpretation.
  → *Thesis-driven essay*: claim, evidence, counterargument.
- **Social Sciences:** explain social phenomena systematically.
  → *IMRaD structure: Introduction → Methods → Results → Discussion*.
- **Linguistics:** mix of humanities and science.
  → *Intro → Background → Data/Methods → Analysis → Discussion → Conclusion.*
- **Computer Science:** emphasize reproducibility and innovation.
  → *Intro → Related Work → Method → Data → Experiments/Results → Analysis → Conclusion.*
- **Hybrids:** combine approaches (e.g., literature review + case study; policy analysis + recommendations).

Developing a Thesis — Chapter Overview

- The **thesis statement** is the backbone of any essay.
- It defines the argument and gives shape to analysis and evidence.
- A good thesis emerges from **questioning**, not from mere assertion.
- Writing itself helps **discover** the thesis.
- The thesis evolves through **drafting and revision**.

Partly based on Creating a Thesis (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 3)

Thesis as a Map for the Reader

- The thesis signals what evidence matters.
- Each paragraph should support or test part of the claim.
- Readers use it to navigate your logic.
- Keep it visible—state it early and restate (refined) in the conclusion.
- Avoid burying the thesis in background or description.

Types of Thesis Statements

- **Analytical**: interprets and explains evidence. (e.g., “The novel critiques capitalism through its fragmented narration.”)
- **Expository**: explains a concept or process. (useful for background essays)
- **Argumentative**: takes a position and justifies it. (most common in humanities writing)
- Choose type according to essay’s purpose.

Summary & Takeaway

- A strong thesis:
  - Arises from inquiry.
  - Makes a specific, arguable claim.
  - Guides structure and evidence.
- Expect to revise it multiple times.
- Use feedback and reflection to sharpen the argument.
- Every paragraph should earn its place by advancing the thesis.
- Writing = continual **refinement of thought**.
- Different tasks have different goals
  - You must adjust your writing style to fit the goal
  - Different disciplines have different styles

Deduction and Induction in Practice

- **Deduction**: from accepted premises to a specific conclusion.

⇒ In real essays, premises are rarely beyond dispute—state them clearly.

- **Induction**: from specific data to generalization; always provisional.

⇒ Match claim strength to evidence quality and scope.

- Use both modes as needed; **hybrid** arguments are common.

Finding Building Blocks

- Gather: **facts, quotations, data, prior interpretations**.
- Note how each item **functions** (example, counterexample, definition).
- Separate **summary** from **analysis** in notes.
- Track source details for citation and revisiting.
- Prune items that don't advance the **central claim**.

Sequencing and Emphasis

- Order points to create **momentum** (e.g., simple → complex).
- Front-load definitions; defer **nuances** until foundations are set.
- Place your strongest section where it has **maximum impact**.
- Use headings and transitions to signal **hierarchy** and shifts.
- Revisit sequence after drafting; **reshuffle** if clarity improves.